

Structured Evaluation of Silka Using the Six Thinking Hats Method

Project Decision: Should Silka prioritise discretion or immediate usability?

1. Introduction

Silka is a discreet mobile safety app designed to help women trigger an emergency response without drawing attention. One of the main design challenges in this project is finding the right balance between discretion and usability.

If the app is too obvious, it may become unsafe in the wrong situation. If it is too hidden, it may be difficult to use quickly under stress. To evaluate this design decision, the Six Thinking Hats method was used.

2. White Hat – Facts

Silka is designed as a covert safety app. The current prototype uses a weather app disguise and includes:

- a hidden access word
- a trigger word (voice and text)
- a setup flow
- a Safe Mode countdown

The app handles sensitive user information, so storing setup details locally is more suitable at this stage. It is also important to consider that emergency situations often involve stress, panic, and fear.

3. Red Hat – Feelings and Intuition

A discreet interface may help the user feel safer because it does not immediately look like an emergency app. At the same time, if too much is hidden, the user may feel unsure or anxious about whether it would work properly during an emergency.

In stressful situations, people may forget the trigger word or hesitate, so the app needs to feel private while still giving the user confidence.

4. Black Hat – Risks and Weaknesses

If the interface is too hidden, the user may not remember how to activate help quickly enough. Hidden actions may also slow the user down in an emergency.

Another weakness is that voice trigger features may not always work well in noisy or stressful conditions.

Another design challenge is the cancel action. If cancellation is too visible, it may reduce the discreet nature of the app. If it is too hidden, the user may not be able to stop a false trigger quickly enough.

5. Yellow Hat – Benefits and Opportunities

The discreet design is one of Silka's biggest strengths. It makes the app feel safer and less suspicious, which supports the main purpose of the project.

Local storage also supports privacy and user trust. Overall, the hidden design gives Silka a unique and meaningful value.

6. Green Hat – Creative Alternatives

Some ideas that could improve the balance between discretion and usability are:

- allowing both typed and voice trigger
- adding a subtle hidden hint for the real user
- letting the user customise the disguise style
- adding a practice mode
- designing a discreet but easy-to-remember cancellation method

7. Blue Hat – Summary and Decision

After reviewing the design decision from different perspectives, the best direction is clear:

Silka should prioritise discretion, but not at the cost of usability.

The app should remain hidden in appearance, but the core actions must stay simple, memorable, and fast for the intended user.

8. Conclusion

The Six Thinking Hats method was useful because it helped evaluate Silka beyond just the technical side. It showed that the project is not only about building features, but also about making careful and balanced design choices.